

The Woman in Room 9

A Psychological Thriller

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Rohit Tak

First Edition - 2026

Table of Contents

Chapter One - The Wake-Up	3
Chapter Two - The Notebook	9
Chapter Three - Room 9	13
Chapter Four - The Photograph	17
Chapter Five - The Missing Woman	21
Chapter Six - The First Lie	25
Chapter Seven - The Recording	27
Chapter Eight - The Memory	29
Chapter Nine - The Locked Archive	33
Chapter Ten - The Woman Who Knows	35
Chapter Eleven - The Second Truth	39
Chapter Twelve - The Night Of Rain	43
Chapter Thirteen - The Confession	45
Chapter Fourteen - Room 9	49
Chapter Fifteen - The Last Page	51
AFTERWORD	55

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

57

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DISCLAIMER

This novel contains themes involving psychological distress, trauma, memory loss, manipulation, confinement, and murder.

It is a work of fiction and is not intended to provide medical or psychological advice. Mental health conditions and treatment are complex and vary greatly from person to person.

DEDICATION

For everyone who has ever questioned a memory-
and wondered whether the truth was hiding somewhere inside it.

Chapter One - The Wake-Up

The first thing Mara Vale noticed was the smell.

Not the pain in her head.

Not the unfamiliar ceiling above her.

Not even the strange pressure around her left wrist.

The smell.

Bleach.

Sharp, clean, medicinal bleach.

It filled the room so completely that she could almost taste it.

Mara opened her eyes.

A white ceiling stared back at her.

For several seconds, she didn't move.

A fluorescent light hummed above her. One of its tubes flickered every few seconds, creating a brief pulse of darkness.

She tried to remember where she was.

Nothing.

She turned her head.

A narrow bed.

A small table.

A plastic chair.

A window with thick glass.

No curtains.

No television.

No phone.

The door was painted pale gray and had no visible handle on the inside.

Mara swallowed.

Her mouth was dry.

She lifted her left hand.

A thin plastic hospital bracelet circled her wrist.

MARA VALE

Underneath her name was a date.
She stared at it.
August 7.
She knew that date.
She simply didn't know why it mattered.
A sudden headache cut through her skull.
Mara closed her eyes.
Rain.
That was the first image.
Rain striking a windshield.
A woman's breathing.
Fast.
Terrified.
Then a voice.
Don't open the door.
Mara's eyes snapped open.
She sat upright.
"Hello?"
Her voice sounded weak.
No answer.
She swung her legs over the side of the bed.
The floor was cold beneath her bare feet.
She stood.
The room tilted.
Mara grabbed the table.
A moment later, the dizziness passed.
She walked toward the door.
"Hello?"
This time, someone answered.
"You're awake."
Mara froze.
A woman's voice.
Calm.
Close.
She looked at the door.
"Who are you?"
A lock clicked.

The door opened.

A woman in a dark blue uniform entered.

She was perhaps fifty years old, with gray hair pulled into a tight bun and an expression that seemed permanently caught between concern and suspicion.

She carried a tray.

Water.

Toast.

Medicine.

“My name is Helen Ward,” the woman said. “I’m one of the nurses here.”

“Where am I?”

Helen put the tray down.

“You don’t remember?”

“No.”

The nurse looked at her for a long moment.

Then she smiled.

Not warmly.

Carefully.

“You’re at Bellwood.”

“What is Bellwood?”

“A psychiatric treatment center.”

Mara stared at her.

“No.”

Helen’s expression didn’t change.

“I don’t belong in a psychiatric center.”

“I know.”

“You know?”

“I know you don’t believe you belong here.”

Mara stepped closer.

“Who brought me here?”

Helen hesitated.

“You did.”

Silence.

Mara almost laughed.

“I did?”

“Yes.”

“When?”

Helen looked toward the small clock above the door.

“Three weeks ago.”

Mara felt the room become strangely quiet.

“That’s impossible.”

“You’ve been here since July seventeenth.”

Mara shook her head.

“No.”

Helen didn’t argue.

Instead, she reached into her pocket and removed a small key.

“Dr. Mercer will see you in twenty minutes.”

“Who is Dr. Mercer?”

“Your physician.”

“I don’t have a physician.”

Helen looked at her.

“You do now.”

She turned to leave.

Mara grabbed her arm.

“Wait.”

Helen stopped.

“Please.”

The nurse looked down at Mara’s hand.

Mara released her.

“Why can’t I remember?”

Helen’s face softened for the first time.

“That’s what Dr. Mercer is going to help you understand.”

The door began to close.

Mara suddenly remembered something.

A woman’s voice.

A whisper.

Whatever they tell you, don’t believe them.

She stared at the closing door.

“Who is Elena?”

Helen stopped.

Only for half a second.

But Mara saw it.

The hesitation.

The tiny change in her eyes.

Then the door closed.

The lock clicked.

Mara stood alone.

And for the first time since waking, she was afraid.

Not because she couldn't remember why she was there.

Because somebody else seemed to remember for her.

Chapter Two - The Notebook

Dr. Adrian Mercer arrived twenty-three minutes later.

Mara knew because she watched the clock.

He was tall, perhaps in his late forties, with silver at his temples and a face that seemed deliberately expressionless.

He carried no medical bag.

Only a folder.

“Mara.”

She didn’t answer.

He sat in the chair.

“You’ve been unconscious for several hours.”

“You told me I’ve been here for three weeks.”

“You have.”

“Then why did I wake up today?”

Mercer opened the folder.

“Because you asked us to let you sleep.”

“I asked?”

“Repeatedly.”

Mara leaned forward.

“What happened to me?”

Mercer studied her.

“You suffered an acute dissociative episode.”

“Why?”

“We’re still determining that.”

“What do you think caused it?”

“Trauma.”

“What trauma?”

He didn’t answer.

Mara felt irritation rising.

“You keep saying things as if I’m supposed to know them.”

"You knew them when you arrived."

"Then tell me."

Mercer closed the folder.

"You weren't ready."

"I am now."

"No."

His answer was so immediate that Mara went still.

Mercer stood.

"I'll see you tomorrow."

"Wait."

He reached the door.

"Dr. Mercer."

He turned.

"Did I hurt anyone?"

A pause.

"No."

The answer should have comforted her.

It didn't.

Because he had looked away when he said it.

That night, Mara couldn't sleep.

At 2:17 a.m., she heard footsteps in the corridor.

Slow.

Measured.

They stopped outside her door.

Mara held her breath.

A shadow appeared beneath the door.

Someone stood outside.

Then the footsteps continued.

She waited.

Ten minutes.

Twenty.

Eventually, she climbed out of bed.

Her eyes had adjusted to the darkness.

She searched the room.

Nothing.

Then she noticed something beneath the mattress.

A corner of paper.

Mara pulled it free.

It was a black notebook.

Her hands trembled.

She opened it.

The handwriting was unmistakably hers.

She recognized the way she crossed her t's.

The way her lowercase "y" curved sharply beneath the line.

The first page contained a single sentence.

If you're reading this, they failed to keep you asleep.

Mara stopped breathing.

She turned the page.

My name is Mara Vale.

Another page.

I am writing this because I know I will forget.

Another.

Don't trust Dr. Mercer.

Mara's pulse accelerated.

She turned pages faster.

Dates.

Names.

Fragments.

Descriptions of conversations.

Then she reached the final section.

Her handwriting became messier.

August 8 - Helen will bring breakfast at 7:30. She will say the coffee machine is broken. It isn't.

Mara looked at the clock.

2:31 a.m.

The next page read:

At 9:00, Mercer will ask whether I remember Elena.

Mara stared.

She remembered Helen.

She remembered Mercer.

And she remembered saying Elena's name.

The next sentence made her stomach tighten.

When he asks, tell him you don't know who Elena is.

Below it was another line.

Because the first person who tells you Elena is dead is lying.

Mara slowly closed the notebook.

She looked at the locked door.

Then at the black window.

Someone had known she would forget.

Someone had prepared instructions for her future self.

Her own handwriting had left her a warning.

And there was only one question she could think of.

If Mara had written the notebook before losing her memory-

what had she been afraid of?

Chapter Three - Room 9

The next morning, Helen arrived at exactly 7:30.

Mara watched her through the observation window.

A cup of coffee.

Toast.

Two tablets.

Exactly as the notebook predicted.

Helen entered.

"The coffee machine is broken again," she said.

Mara felt cold.

She had never met Helen before yesterday.

Yet the notebook had known.

Helen placed the tray on the table.

"Did you sleep?"

"Not much."

"Nightmares?"

"No."

Helen looked at her.

Mara smiled.

It was the first lie she had told since waking.

Helen left.

Mara waited until the corridor was quiet.

Then she slipped the notebook beneath her pillow.

At nine, Dr. Mercer entered.

He sat.

"How are you feeling?"

"Confused."

"Do you remember anything?"

Mara looked directly at him.

"Elena."

Mercer's expression changed.

Barely.

"Who is Elena?"

The question echoed through the room.

Mara remembered the notebook.

Tell him you don't know.

"I don't know."

Mercer smiled.

"Good."

Mara felt her stomach tighten.

"Good?"

"Your memory is beginning to stabilize."

He stood.

"There's something you should understand about Bellwood."

"What?"

"Not every patient here knows what is real."

He left.

Mara stared at the closed door.

Later that afternoon, she was allowed into the common room.

Four patients sat around the edges.

No one spoke.

Mara noticed the woman in the corner immediately.

She was young, perhaps thirty.

Dark hair.

Pale skin.

A scar above her eyebrow.

She was drawing circles on a piece of paper.

When Mara walked past, the woman looked up.

"You're new."

Mara stopped.

"I've been here three weeks."

The woman smiled.

"That's not what I meant."

Mara glanced around.

"What do you mean?"

The woman leaned closer.

"You're the woman from Room 9."

Mara frowned.

"I'm not in Room 9."

The woman looked toward the corridor.

"Yes, you are."

Mara felt a chill.

"What happens in Room 9?"

The woman's smile disappeared.

"Nothing."

"Then why are you afraid?"

"I'm not."

"What's your name?"

The woman hesitated.

"Clara."

"Clara what?"

"Don't ask."

Mara lowered her voice.

"Do you know Elena?"

Clara's face went white.

She stood abruptly.

"You shouldn't say that name."

"Why?"

"Because she can hear you."

Mara almost laughed.

But Clara wasn't joking.

"Elena is dead," Clara whispered.

"Who told you?"

Clara stared directly into Mara's eyes.

"You did."

Mara's breath caught.

Before she could ask another question, Clara walked away.

That night, Mara returned to her room.

The black notebook was still beneath her pillow.

She opened it.

A new sentence had appeared on the final page.

Mara stared at it.

She knew she hadn't written it.

CLARA IS NOT A PATIENT.

Below that:

AND SHE KNOWS WHAT YOU DID.

Chapter Four - The Photograph

Mara didn't sleep.

At dawn, she searched the room again.

This time, she found something taped beneath the underside of the table.

A photograph.

Old.

Faded.

Two women stood outside a house.

One was Mara.

She recognized herself instantly.

The other woman was younger.

Dark hair.

Pale face.

A scar above her eyebrow.

Clara.

Mara dropped the photograph.

Her hands began shaking.

She picked it up again.

On the back was a date.

October 14, 2018.

Eight years ago.

Underneath:

Mara + Elena - Bellwood House

Mara stared at the photograph.

Bellwood House.

Not Bellwood Clinic.

She turned it over.

On the front, she and Elena were smiling.

They looked happy.

Comfortable.

Like friends.

Mara couldn't remember her.

She ran to the door.

"Helen!"

The nurse appeared several minutes later.

Mara held up the photograph.

"Who is she?"

Helen's face changed.

"Where did you get that?"

"Answer me."

Helen reached for it.

Mara pulled it away.

"Who is Elena?"

Helen looked frightened.

Not surprised.

Frightened.

"You need to give me that."

"Why?"

"Because it's not yours."

"It's a photograph of me."

Helen said nothing.

Mara stepped closer.

"Why does it say Bellwood House?"

Helen's lips parted.

Then closed.

"Ask Dr. Mercer."

"I did."

"What did he say?"

"He said he didn't know Elena."

Helen looked toward the corridor.

Then whispered:

"Then he lied."

Mara felt the world shift beneath her.

"What happened here?"

Helen's eyes filled with tears.

"Eight years ago, this wasn't a clinic."

"What was it?"

"A private house."

"Whose?"

Helen looked at the photograph.

"Yours."

Mara couldn't breathe.

"My house?"

Helen nodded.

"You lived here."

A terrible headache exploded behind Mara's eyes.

Rain.

A hallway.

A locked door.

A woman screaming.

Then a man's voice:

"Mara, don't make me do this."

Mara stumbled backward.

Helen caught her.

"What did I do?"

Helen stared at her.

"You need to remember."

"Tell me."

"I can't."

"Why?"

Helen whispered:

"Because you asked me never to."

Chapter Five - The Missing Woman

Mara spent the next day searching for information.

She learned that Bellwood Clinic had been established in 2021.

Before that, the property had been owned by a private trust.

The trust belonged to the Vale family.

Her family.

She found this information in an old newspaper stored in the clinic library.

There was a photograph of the house.

The same house from the photograph.

The article was dated October 15, 2018.

LOCAL WOMAN MISSING AFTER PRIVATE PARTY

The woman's name:

Elena Cross, 29.

Mara read the article twice.

Then again.

Elena had disappeared from the Vale residence during a storm.

Police had investigated.

No body had been found.

No charges were filed.

Mara was mentioned in the article.

She had hosted the party.

She had told police that Elena left alone.

Mara closed the newspaper.

She remembered none of it.

That evening, Clara approached her in the corridor.

"You found her."

"Elena?"

Clara nodded.

"You remember?"

"No."

"You will."

Mara grabbed Clara's wrist.

"Who are you?"

Clara looked down.

"Someone who survived."

"Survived what?"

"Her."

"Elena?"

Clara shook her head.

"You."

Mara released her.

Clara walked away.

Mara followed.

"Wait."

Clara stopped.

"You said you're not a patient."

Clara looked over her shoulder.

"I'm not."

"Then why are you here?"

"Because you put me here."

Mara froze.

"What?"

Clara smiled sadly.

"You really don't remember."

She disappeared through a doorway.

Mara followed.

The door led to an empty hallway.

No Clara.

No footsteps.

Nothing.

That night, Mara searched the patient records.

There was no Clara.

No patient.

No employee.

No visitor.

Nothing.

She returned to her room.

The notebook lay open on the bed.

Mara hadn't left it there.

A sentence had been written across the page.

**YOU ARE LOOKING FOR THE WRONG MISSING
WOMAN.**

Chapter Six - The First Lie

Mara confronted Dr. Mercer.

“Where is Clara?”

He stared at her.

“Who?”

“Clara.”

“I don’t know anyone by that name.”

“The woman with the scar.”

Mercer closed his folder.

“There are several patients with scars.”

“Not her.”

He said nothing.

Mara placed the photograph on his desk.

His eyes fell on Elena.

For the first time, Mara saw genuine fear.

“You know her.”

“No.”

“You lied.”

Mercer stood.

“Where did you get this?”

“You know where.”

“Who gave it to you?”

“Did Elena disappear from this house?”

Mercer didn’t answer.

“Did I know her?”

Silence.

“Did I kill her?”

Mercer’s face became completely still.

“No.”

The word was quiet.

"Then what happened?"

"You weren't responsible for Elena's disappearance."

Mara caught the distinction.

"You said I wasn't responsible."

"I said you weren't responsible for her disappearance."

"What does that mean?"

Mercer looked at the clock.

"You need to rest."

Mara laughed bitterly.

"Everyone keeps telling me to rest."

She walked toward the door.

Mercer spoke.

"Mara."

She stopped.

"You should stop looking for answers."

"Why?"

"Because you may not like what you find."

Mara turned.

"That's the point."

Mercer looked at her.

Then said something that changed everything.

"You didn't come here to find Elena."

Mara's heart stopped.

"You came here to forget her."

Chapter Seven - The Recording

The recorder was hidden inside the wall.

Mara found it after noticing a loose panel behind the bed.

It was tiny.

Black.

Old.

There was one button.

PLAY.

She pressed it.

Static.

Then her own voice.

If you're hearing this, I'm probably back in Room 9.

Mara stopped breathing.

Her recorded voice sounded tired.

Afraid.

You need to listen carefully.

A pause.

Elena isn't the person you think she is.

Mara stared at the recorder.

The voice continued.

And neither am I.

Static.

Then another voice.

A man's.

Mercer.

"Are you certain?"

Her recorded voice answered.

"Yes."

“Once we do this, you can’t undo it.”

“I know.”

“Your memory may not return.”

“That’s why I’m doing it.”

Mara’s fingers tightened around the recorder.

Mercer asked:

“What are you afraid you’ll remember?”

Her voice answered:

“The ninth memory.”

The recording ended.

Mara sat on the floor.

The ninth memory.

She had never heard those words before.

Yet something inside her recognized them.

She closed her eyes.

A door.

Rain.

A bedroom.

Nine photographs pinned to a wall.

Eight crossed out.

One untouched.

A woman’s face.

Elena.

Mara opened her eyes.

She suddenly knew where the ninth memory was.

Room 9.

Chapter Eight - The Memory

The clinic's basement was forbidden.

Mara discovered that through a fire-exit map.

Room 9 was not on the current floor plan.

But an old floor plan showed it.

Basement level.

Mara waited until midnight.

Then she stole Helen's key.

The basement smelled of damp concrete.

The lights flickered.

At the end of the corridor was a steel door.

A number had been scratched into it.

9

Mara unlocked it.

Inside was a bedroom.

Not a hospital room.

A real bedroom.

Old wallpaper.

A wooden wardrobe.

A cracked mirror.

Nine photographs covered one wall.

Mara approached them.

Eight were crossed out.

The ninth was Elena.

Underneath was a handwritten sentence:

SHE REMEMBERED.

Mara touched the photograph.

The memory came.

Not gradually.

Violently.

She was standing in this room eight years earlier.

Elena was crying.

“You can’t keep doing this.”

Mara was shouting.

“You’re going to destroy everything.”

Elena shook her head.

“No. I’m going to tell the truth.”

“What truth?”

“About Daniel.”

Mara froze.

Daniel.

Her husband.

Elena had discovered something about him.

Something terrible.

Mara remembered another flash.

Daniel entering the room.

Rainwater dripping from his coat.

Elena screaming.

A struggle.

Then a loud crack.

Silence.

Mara remembered blood.

But she couldn’t remember whose.

The memory broke.

Mara fell to her knees.

Someone stood behind her.

“Now you remember.”

She turned.

Clara.

Except it wasn’t Clara.

The scar was makeup.

The dark hair was a wig.

Mara stared.

“Who are you?”

The woman removed the wig.

Her hair was short.

Gray.

Older.

Mara recognized her.

“Helen?”

Helen’s eyes filled with tears.

“No.”

She removed the scar.

“I was Elena’s mother.”

Chapter Nine - The Locked Archive

Helen told Mara the truth.

Elena had been investigating Daniel.

He had been stealing money from clients through his investment company.

Elena discovered the fraud.

She threatened to expose him.

Daniel panicked.

Mara confronted him.

A fight followed.

But Helen said something was missing.

“Where is Elena?”

Mara stared at her.

“You said she disappeared.”

“I said you weren’t responsible for her disappearance.”

“Was Daniel?”

Helen looked away.

“No.”

Mara’s blood ran cold.

“Then who?”

Helen didn’t answer.

Mara noticed a metal cabinet in the corner.

She opened it.

Inside were files.

Her name appeared on nearly every folder.

MARA VALE - MEMORY TREATMENT

MARA VALE - SESSION 01

MARA VALE - SESSION 02

And another:

ELENA CROSS - CASE CLOSED

Mara opened it.

Inside was a death certificate.

Elena Cross.

Cause of death:

Blunt-force trauma.

Date of death:

October 14, 2018.

Mara stared at the paper.

“She’s dead.”

Helen nodded.

“Yes.”

“Then why did you keep pretending she wasn’t?”

“Because you needed to remember.”

Mara looked at her.

“What happened that night?”

Helen whispered:

“Elena wasn’t killed by Daniel.”

Mara’s heart pounded.

“Who killed her?”

Helen pointed to the final file.

Mara opened it.

There was a photograph.

Daniel.

Mara.

And Elena.

All three standing together.

The photograph had been taken hours before Elena died.

On the back was a message.

THE PERSON WHO KILLED ELENA IS STILL ALIVE.

Mara looked at Helen.

“Who?”

Helen shook her head.

“You already know.”

Chapter Ten - The Woman Who Knows

Mara returned upstairs.

Dr. Mercer was waiting.

"You went downstairs."

She didn't answer.

"You weren't supposed to."

"Elena is dead."

Mercer nodded.

"Yes."

"You knew."

"Yes."

"Why did you make me forget?"

Mercer sat.

"Because you asked me to."

"Why?"

"Because you couldn't live with what happened."

Mara stared at him.

"Who killed her?"

Mercer looked at her for a long time.

Then he said:

"You did."

The room seemed to disappear.

Mara laughed.

"No."

"You struck her."

"No."

"You pushed her."

"No."

“She fell.”

Mara covered her ears.

“Stop.”

“You killed Elena.”

“No!”

Mercer remained silent.

Mara’s breathing became rapid.

Images flooded her mind.

Elena.

The argument.

The blood.

Her hands.

A broken lamp.

Elena falling.

Mara screaming.

Then another image.

Daniel standing in the doorway.

Watching.

Not helping.

Mara whispered:

“Why didn’t he call the police?”

Mercer answered:

“Because he was afraid.”

“Of what?”

“Of you.”

Mara looked at him.

“What did I do?”

Mercer said:

“You told him that if Elena died, you would tell the police everything about his financial crimes.”

Mara stared.

Mercer continued.

“He helped you hide the body.”

Mara couldn’t speak.

“Where?”

Mercer pointed toward the window.

“The lake.”

Mara suddenly remembered water.
Dark water.
A heavy object sinking.
Her own hands trembling.
But something was wrong.
One detail didn't fit.
She had remembered Elena falling.
She had remembered the blood.
But she had never remembered seeing Elena's body after the fall.
Why?

Chapter Eleven - The Second Truth

Mara found the answer in the mirror.

A small scratch on her cheek.

Three lines.

She remembered seeing them before.

In the photograph.

But the photograph had been taken before Elena's death.

The scratch was already there.

That meant the fight had happened earlier.

Not that night.

Mara returned to the archive.

She searched the files again.

There was a security report.

October 13.

One day before Elena disappeared.

Physical altercation between Mara Vale and Elena Cross.

Mara read the report.

Then she found something else.

A second death certificate.

Not Elena.

Daniel Vale.

Date of death:

October 16, 2018.

Mara's stomach dropped.

Daniel had died two days after Elena.

But everyone at Bellwood had spoken about him as though he were alive.

Mara ran to Mercer.

"Daniel is dead."

Mercer said nothing.

"Why did you let me believe he was alive?"

"Because you believed it."

"That doesn't answer me."

Mercer looked exhausted.

"You created him."

Mara stared.

"What?"

"After Elena died, you developed a psychological projection of Daniel."

"No."

"You spoke to him."

"No."

"You argued with him."

"No."

"You blamed him."

Mara stepped backward.

Mercer continued.

"But Daniel had been dead for years."

Mara's mind raced.

The voice.

The hallway.

The man in the doorway.

Every conversation.

Every warning.

Daniel had never been there.

She had imagined him.

Then Mara remembered something else.

The notebook.

The handwriting.

The sentence:

CLARA IS NOT A PATIENT.

She suddenly understood.

There had never been a Clara.

There had never been an Elena inside the clinic.

There had only been Mara.

And the people she had created to survive the truth.

Or so she thought.

Chapter Twelve - The Night Of Rain

Mara asked Mercer for the original case file.

He hesitated.

Then gave it to her.

The first pages were medical reports.

The final page was handwritten.

By Mara.

She read it.

Elena didn't fall.

Her hands began shaking.

The next sentence:

I pushed her.

Mara closed her eyes.

The memory returned.

Elena had discovered Daniel's fraud.

But there was another secret.

Mara had discovered that Elena was having an affair with Daniel.

The argument had begun with betrayal.

It had become violence.

Elena threatened to expose both of them.

Mara pushed her.

Elena hit the table.

She died instantly.

Daniel arrived afterward.

He helped Mara hide the body.

Two days later, Daniel tried to blackmail her.

Mara killed him.

The memories crashed together.

Two deaths.

One secret.

One woman unable to live with either.

But there was one final page.

Mara turned it over.

I didn't kill Daniel.

She stared at the sentence.

Then another:

He was already dead when I found him.

Mara looked at Mercer.

"Who killed Daniel?"

Mercer said nothing.

"Tell me."

"I can't."

"Why?"

"Because you haven't remembered that part yet."

Mara looked at the final line.

When you remember who killed Daniel, you'll understand why Room 9 exists.

A noise came from the corridor.

Footsteps.

Mara turned.

Helen stood in the doorway.

She was crying.

"Now," Helen whispered, "you remember enough."

Chapter Thirteen - The Confession

Helen locked the door behind her.

Mara stared at her.

“You’re Elena’s mother.”

“Yes.”

“You killed Daniel.”

Helen nodded.

“Why?”

“Because he killed my daughter.”

“He didn’t.”

“No.”

Helen’s eyes hardened.

“But he helped you hide her body.”

“Yes.”

“And then he threatened you.”

“Yes.”

Helen stepped closer.

“I followed him.”

She explained what happened.

Daniel had gone to the lake to move Elena’s body.

Helen confronted him.

They fought.

Daniel fell.

He died.

Helen buried the evidence.

Then she found Mara.

Mara was broken.

Unable to distinguish memory from imagination.

Helen could have sent her to prison.

Instead, she helped Mercer create Bellwood.

A controlled environment.

A place where Mara could reconstruct her memories safely.

But there was one problem.

Mara had begun remembering Elena before the treatment was complete.

“So you pretended to be Clara.”

Helen nodded.

“Why?”

“Because you needed someone to lead you to the truth.”

Mara stared at her.

“And the notebook?”

Helen looked confused.

“I didn’t write it.”

Mara’s blood turned cold.

“Then who did?”

Helen shook her head.

“I don’t know.”

The room fell silent.

Mara slowly looked toward the bed.

The black notebook was there.

Open.

A new page had been written.

HELLO, MARA.

She stepped closer.

Below it:

THEY TOLD YOU THE TRUTH.

Then:

BUT NOT ALL OF IT.

Mara’s breathing stopped.

Helen whispered:

“What is that?”

Mara turned the page.

YOU HAVE NEVER BEEN IN BELLWOOD FOR THREE WEEKS.

The next line:

YOU HAVE BEEN HERE FOR EIGHT YEARS.

Chapter Fourteen - Room 9

Mara couldn't move.

Eight years.

The photographs.

The files.

The dates.

Everything suddenly looked different.

She turned to Mercer.

"How long?"

He said nothing.

"How long have I been here?"

"Eight years."

Mara laughed.

A terrible, empty sound.

"No."

"You asked us to keep you here."

"Why?"

"Because every time we released you, you tried to find Elena."

"But Elena is dead."

"Yes."

"Then what was I looking for?"

Mercer looked at Helen.

Helen shook her head.

Mercer finally said:

"The truth about yourself."

Mara opened the notebook again.

The handwriting had changed.

It wasn't hers.

It belonged to someone else.

She recognized it.

Elena's handwriting.

Mara dropped the book.

Helen picked it up.

Her face went white.

"This is impossible."

Mara stared at the page.

A message:

MARA, IF YOU CAN READ THIS, THEY FAILED.

Helen whispered:

"Elena..."

Mara took the notebook.

There was a photograph tucked inside.

Elena.

Alive.

Standing beside Mara.

The date was eight years old.

On the back:

I KNEW WHAT MARA DID.

Then:

BUT I DIDN'T DIE THAT NIGHT.

Mara felt her entire body go cold.

The door opened.

A woman stood in the corridor.

Dark hair.

Pale face.

Scar above her eyebrow.

Mara couldn't breathe.

Helen dropped the notebook.

The woman smiled.

"Hello, Mara."

Mara whispered:

"Elena."

Elena nodded.

"I've been waiting eight years for you to remember me."

Chapter Fifteen - The Last Page

Nobody moved.

Mara stared at Elena.

The woman looked older than the photograph.

But unmistakable.

“You died.”

Elena smiled.

“That’s what they wanted you to believe.”

Mara looked at Helen.

Helen was crying.

“You knew.”

Elena answered for her.

“She knew.”

“Why?”

“Because you tried to kill me.”

Mara remembered.

The argument.

The push.

Elena falling.

But then-

Elena getting up.

Blood on her forehead.

Alive.

Walking away.

Mara’s memory had stopped there.

Everything after had been constructed.

“Daniel found you,” Elena said.

Mara looked at her.

"He tried to kill me."

"Why?"

"Because I knew about his crimes."

Mara's head spun.

"You survived."

"Yes."

"Then why disappear?"

"Because I was afraid."

"Of Daniel?"

Elena looked at Mara.

"Of you."

Mara said nothing.

Elena continued.

"You weren't the woman you thought you were."

Mara's eyes filled with tears.

"What does that mean?"

"You didn't lose your memory."

Mara froze.

"You chose it."

The room became silent.

Elena walked toward her.

"After Daniel died, you came to me."

Mara shook her head.

"No."

"You begged me to help you disappear."

"No."

"You told me you couldn't live with what you'd done."

Mara's eyes closed.

A memory surfaced.

Not a violent one.

A quiet one.

Mara sitting across from Elena.

Crying.

Asking for help.

Then writing in the notebook.

I need to forget.

Mara opened her eyes.

“You helped me.”

Elena nodded.

“Yes.”

“Why?”

“Because despite everything, I loved you.”

Mara couldn’t speak.

Elena reached into her coat.

She pulled out a final photograph.

Mara looked at it.

It showed three women.

Mara.

Elena.

Helen.

Standing outside Bellwood.

The photograph was recent.

Very recent.

On the back was a date:

August 8, 2026.

Tomorrow.

Mara stared at the date.

“What is this?”

Elena smiled.

“The reason you’re awake.”

Mara’s stomach tightened.

“What happens tomorrow?”

Elena didn’t answer.

Instead, she gave Mara the notebook.

The final page was blank.

“Write it,” Elena said.

“Write what?”

“The memory you haven’t remembered yet.”

Mara looked at the page.

Her hand began to move.

She didn’t know what she was writing.

But the words came anyway.

I didn’t kill Elena.

She stopped.

A second sentence appeared beneath it.

I didn't kill Daniel.

Her hand continued.

A third line.

I killed the woman who was pretending to be Elena.

Mara dropped the pen.

She looked up.

Elena was gone.

Helen was gone.

Mercer was gone.

The room was empty.

Mara ran to the door.

Locked.

She turned toward the mirror.

For the first time, she noticed the reflection.

It wasn't hers.

It was Elena's.

Mara stepped backward.

The reflection smiled.

Then it spoke.

Not aloud.

Inside her mind.

You finally remembered.

Mara looked down at the notebook.

The final page was no longer blank.

One last sentence had appeared.

ROOM 9 WAS NEVER A ROOM.

Mara stared.

The fluorescent light above her flickered.

Once.

Twice.

Then darkness.

AFTERWORD

Some memories protect us.

Others imprison us.

And sometimes the most dangerous thing a person can forget is not what happened-

but **why they chose to forget it.**

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Rohit Tak

Rohit Tak is an author interested in stories that explore human psychology, hidden motives, unreliable memories, and the secrets people keep from themselves.

His work focuses on suspenseful storytelling, unexpected revelations, and characters whose understanding of reality is constantly challenged.

The Woman in Room 9 is his psychological thriller exploring memory, guilt, identity, and the thin line between truth and perception.

